II—Return

> ‘Alas! that the Emperor Humayun died so early and that I had no opportunity of showing him faithful service!’
>
> – Akbar, Happy Sayings, *Ain-i-Akbari*

A year had not passed when Akbar the refugee became also a hostage. For much of the first decade of his life, in fact, the prince was to be shunted between malevolent uncles and ministering aunts, in the wake of his father’s fluctuating fortunes. For most of these years, any thought of resuscitating his rule in Hindustan must have retreated to the deepest recesses of Humayun’s mind; his greatest challenge would no longer be Sher Shah, but Kamran, his greatest ambition no longer Delhi, but Kabul. To lower one’s ambitions by such scale cannot be easy for anyone, let alone for a padishah, and it would be a while before Humayun was able to bring himself to do so. He would have to fall to the very pits of his fortune first, bereft of even a pebble to rule, bereft of even his son. And, as befits a life of such Grecian drama, the fall would be of Humayun’s own making, the result of his own tragic flaw: self-indulgence.

Within days of Akbar’s birth, Humayun had fought a quick battle and won a riverside town called Jun, then settled down in it for a prolonged rest. The expedition should have carried the momentum of its victory and marched on to attack Shah Husain in Thatta, his capital; and Gulbadan, for one, cannot understand why it didn’t. ‘It is a six days’ journey from Jun to Tatta’, she writes, but Humayun ‘was as much as six months in Jun’.[1] Abul Fazl’s description of Jun goes a long way to explain Humayun’s decision. The town was beautiful, and beautifully located, built along the blue waters of the Indus, ‘eminent . . . for its many gardens, streams, [and] pleasant fruits’.[2] Humayun had suffered a terrible two years; now, with his tents pitched in one of Jun’s lovely gardens, surrounded by its orchards, soothed by the sounds of the river nearby, the exiled emperor may have felt he deserved a little treat. Instead of ordering marches, then, he summoned his family.

On 9 December 1542, when Akbar was just under two months old, he met his father in a lovely little ceremony: Akbar’s head was put to Humayun’s feet, after which the father took the baby in his arms and kissed him.